

KARSHI-KHANABAD (K-2) AIR BASE

Purpose

This fact sheet provides information regarding potential exposures at Karshi- Khanabad (K-2) Air Base.

Audience

VA employees, K-2 Veterans, Veterans Service Organizations, and the general public.

Background

Karshi-Khanabad Air Base, also known as K-2 or Camp Stronghold Freedom, was a Soviet-era air base used by U.S. Army, Air Force, and Marine forces from October 2001 to November 2005 to support missions into Afghanistan. The base was one square mile in southeastern Uzbekistan, near the border of Tajikistan, shown in Figure 1. K-2 is currently home to the 60th Separate Mixed Aviation Brigade of the Uzbek Air Force.

Reports from the [Defense Health Agency](#) shows sub-surface volatile organic compounds, airborne particulate matter, and depleted uranium fragments were present at K-2 prior to U.S. operations in October 2001.



Figure 1. Karshi-Khanabad Air Base, Uzbekistan

Potential Exposures

The table below provides information regarding potential exposures at K-2 from October 2001 to November 2005, the current status, and next steps.

Potential Exposures	Current Status
• Jet fuel • Volatile organic compounds • Particulate matter and dust • Depleted uranium • Asbestos • Lead-based paint • Lead in water samples	VA currently recognizes presumptions related to Burn Pits and Other Toxins (BPOTs) under 38 U.S.C. § 1119 for those deployed to K-2. If an individual served at K-2, has a recognized presumptive condition, and meets other basic eligibility requirements, they may be eligible for presumptions related to BPOT exposure.



Important Information for Claims Processors

- In July 2024, a corporate flash (*Toxic Exposure – Uzbekistan Deployed Veteran*) was added to Veterans Benefits Management System (VBMS) profiles where K-2 service was verified. However, if service at K-2 is specifically claimed and the flash is not present, a claim file review must be completed to verify service.
- A Toxic Exposure Risk Activity (TERA) memorandum and medical opinion may be required prior to making a decision for an individual deployed to K-2 based on the recognized potential exposure:
 - If the Veteran claims a non-presumptive disability or disease and has either the *Toxic Exposure – Uzbekistan Deployed Veteran* or the *Toxic Exposure – Sec. 1119 Covered Veteran* corporate flashes (or other verification of service in Uzbekistan on or after September 11, 2001), then a TERA medical opinion may be warranted based on service in Uzbekistan.
 - If the Veteran claims a presumptive disability or disease listed in 38 U.S.C. § 1120 and has either the *Toxic Exposure – Uzbekistan Deployed Veteran* or the *Toxic Exposure – Sec. 1119 Covered Veteran* corporate flashes (or other verification of service in Uzbekistan on or after September 11, 2001), then an examination may be warranted.
- The Department of Defense (DoD) has confirmed classified missions occurred in K-2. If Special Operations is noted and service is claimed but can't be verified based on a claim file review, follow the

instructions in the [manual](#) regarding claims based on participation in Special Operations incidents.

- The [Veterans Health Administration Public Health site](#) notes exposure to depleted uranium was measured in a restricted, limited access area of K-2; this information is provided to examiners when requesting a TERA examination and medical opinion for consideration of the combined synergistic effects of all exposures. The [Army Public Health Center](#) reports the levels of background radiation at K-2 are well below any threat.

Important Links for Processing Claims

- [M21-1, Part VIII, Subpart ii, Chapter 2, Section A - General Information on Claims Based on Fine Particulate Matter Exposure \(va.gov\)](#)
- [M21-1, Part VIII, Subpart ii, Chapter 2, Section B - Developing Claims Based On Fine Particulate Matter Exposure \(va.gov\)](#)
- [M21-1, Part VIII, Subpart ii, Chapter 2, Section C - Rating Claims Based on Fine Particulate Matter Exposure \(va.gov\)](#)
- [M21-1, Part VIII, Subpart iii, Chapter 9, Section B - Processing Claims Based on Exposure to Specific Environmental or Military Occupational Hazards \(va.gov\)](#)
- [M21-1, Part VIII, Subpart iv, Chapter 9, Section A - Claims Based on Participation in Special Operations Incidents \(va.gov\)](#)
- [M21-1, Part VIII, Subpart iii, Chapter 7, Section B - Development and Examination Requests for Claims Based on Exposure to Asbestos \(va.gov\)](#)

Information for K-2 Veterans, Dependents and Survivors

- VA encourages Veterans to submit a claim if they believe their disability is related to military service. K-2 deployed Veterans are covered for all recognized presumptive disabilities and diseases related to BPOT.
- Veterans who served at K-2 may have been exposed to jet fuel, volatile organic compounds, particulate matter and dust, depleted uranium, asbestos, lead-based paint, and lead in water samples, which are considered TERAs. Therefore, a TERA medical opinion may be warranted based on the potential exposures.
- VA does not require that a condition or location be on a presumptive list to grant a Veteran eligibility to disability compensation benefits. In such cases, VA would consider the claim on a case-by-case basis.
- VA provides Veteran-centric decisions. VA grants disability compensation benefits when there is evidence showing that the Veteran has a current chronic disability related to their military service; therefore, a thorough review of the claims file is often necessary.
- VA is aware that a large number of deployed Veterans were involved in classified missions to K-2. VA is able to verify classified or restricted information using the Military Records Research Center (MRRC).
- If Veterans have any questions or concerns regarding their benefits or claims, contact the VA toll-free number at 1-800-MyVA411 to speak with a VA representative.

Other Resources

- [Karshi Khanabad \(K-2\) Air Base - Public Health \(va.gov\)](https://www.va.gov/k2-health/)
- [Airborne Hazards and Open Burn Pit Registry \(va.gov\)](https://www.va.gov/airborne-hazards/)
- [Public Health- K-2 Potential Contaminants of Concerns \(va.gov\)](https://www.va.gov/public-health/k2/)
- [Defense Health Agency K-2 Air Base Exposures](https://www.va.gov/defense-health/k2/)
- [VA Pact Act information page \(va.gov\)](https://www.va.gov/pact-act/)
- [VA Press Release: VA takes steps to expand access to benefits for Veterans who served at K2 and their survivors](https://www.va.gov/press-release/)
- Visit <https://www.va.gov/> to learn more about VA benefits and services, including how to enroll or apply for benefits.